

AI is used to format the transcript to be clearer

Interview 1

Interviewer: Can you walk me through a recent time at work when a language barrier made a task harder than it needed to be?

Participant: Last week my manager explained a task during our morning meeting. I understood most of it, but he said something like “have a crack at it and circle back later.” I understood the general task, but I wasn’t sure exactly what he expected me to do first. I didn’t want to interrupt the meeting, so afterwards I messaged another graduate and asked what he meant.

Interviewer: In a typical week, how often do you need help understanding instructions, meetings, or conversations from coworkers?

Participant: Maybe two or three times a week. Usually I understand the English words, but sometimes I don’t understand the expression or what the person actually means.

Interviewer: Who do you usually turn to when you don’t understand something at work?

Participant: Usually another graduate employee. I feel more comfortable asking someone who is at the same level as me.

Interviewer: Why do you prefer asking them instead of your manager?

Participant: I don’t want my manager to think my English is not good enough. I know that probably isn’t what they’re thinking, but I still worry about it.

Interviewer: Have you ever avoided asking a question because of the language barrier?

Participant: Yes, especially during meetings. If everyone else seems to understand, I don’t want to stop the discussion just because I’m confused.

Interviewer: What do you normally do instead?

Participant: Sometimes I just write down the word or phrase and search it afterwards. Or I message a coworker privately.

Interviewer: What tools do you currently use?

Participant: Google Translate sometimes, ChatGPT, and my notes. I keep a list of workplace words and phrases I hear a lot.

Interviewer: How well do those tools work?

Participant: They work well after a meeting, but not really during a conversation because everything happens too fast.

Interviewer: When a coworker helps you understand something, what does that usually look like?

Participant: Usually they repeat it more slowly or explain it using different words. Sometimes they send me a written message afterwards. Written explanations are really helpful because I can read them again.

Interviewer: Does it feel different asking for help one-on-one compared with in a group?

Participant: Definitely. One-on-one is much easier.

Interviewer: Why?

Participant: In a group, when I ask a question, suddenly everyone is looking at me. It makes me feel like I'm stopping everyone.

Interviewer: Is there anyone on your team who naturally helps people with language issues?

Participant: There is another coworker who is very good at explaining things. She doesn't just repeat the same sentence. She changes the words and gives examples.

Interviewer: Have you ever felt like you were slowing the group down?

Participant: Yes. Sometimes somebody explains something twice, and I feel like everyone wants to continue. Even if nobody says anything negative, I feel pressure to just say I understand.

Interviewer: Imagine there was a shared robot or device in the room during team conversations that could translate or clarify things in real time. How do you think that would affect you?

Participant: I think it could help me participate more, especially if I could quietly check something I didn't understand.

Interviewer: Would you feel comfortable using it in front of coworkers?

Participant: It depends on how it works. If I have to say out loud, "Robot, translate this for me," then probably not.

Interviewer: Why not?

Participant: Because then everybody knows I'm the person who didn't understand. I would prefer something more private.

Interviewer: Do you think your coworkers would use the device to help you?

Participant: Maybe, if it was normal for everybody to use it. I don't want it to be something only international employees use.

Interviewer: Would you prefer the robot to explain things directly to you, or help your coworkers explain things more clearly?

Participant: Probably both. If it's just a word, direct translation is fine. But sometimes I know all the words and still don't understand what the person expects me to do.

Interviewer: Since the device belongs to the company, would that change how you feel about using it?

Participant: Yes. I would want to know if it records conversations.

Interviewer: What if management could see what you translated or what you didn't understand?

Participant: I wouldn't like that. I might stop using it because I wouldn't want that information connected to my work performance.

Interviewer: Do you think this type of support could improve your relationships with coworkers?

Participant: Maybe. If I understand conversations better, I can participate more. But I still want coworkers to talk to me normally instead of just depending on the robot.

Interviewer: Is there anything a translation tool probably wouldn't solve?

Participant: Sometimes it is the cultural meaning. Like jokes or Australian expressions. Translating the words doesn't always tell me what the person actually means.

Interviewer: If you could design one feature for the robot, what would it be?

Participant: A private clarification feature. Maybe I press a button and it gives me a simple explanation on my phone without interrupting everyone.

Interviewer: Is there anything else about being a non-native English speaker at work that you think is important for us to understand?

Participant: Sometimes I understand more than people think I do. I just need more confidence and maybe a little more time to respond.

Interview 2

Interviewer: Can you tell me about a recent time when language made your work harder?

Participant: During a busy shift, someone shouted an instruction from the other side of the café and I heard one word incorrectly. I misunderstood a change to a customer's order, so we had to remake it.

Interviewer: How often do you need help understanding conversations at work?

Participant: Not every day, but it happens more when the café is really busy.

Interviewer: What makes those situations difficult?

Participant: Noise is a big problem. Also different accents. Sometimes I understand English perfectly in a quiet conversation, but when somebody is speaking quickly with a strong accent and there's music and customers talking, it becomes much harder.

Interviewer: Who do you usually ask for help?

Participant: Whoever is closest to me. I'm pretty comfortable asking coworkers.

Interviewer: What would you normally say?

Participant: Usually just, "Sorry, can you say that again?" or "What do you mean?"

Interviewer: Have you ever avoided asking a question?

Participant: With coworkers, not really. But with customers sometimes.

Interviewer: Why is it different with customers?

Participant: I don't want them to think I'm not professional or that I can't communicate properly.

Interviewer: What tools do you currently use to help with language?

Participant: Sometimes Google Translate for a specific word, but not really during a busy shift.

Interviewer: Why not?

Participant: It's too slow. I can't stop, take out my phone, type something, translate it, and then continue working while everyone is waiting.

Interviewer: When coworkers help you, what kind of explanation works best?

Participant: Showing me usually works best. If someone points to something while explaining it, I understand very quickly.

Interviewer: Does asking for help feel different in a group?

Participant: A little. I don't mind asking, but sometimes in a group there are several conversations happening at the same time.

Interviewer: Does that make communication harder?

Participant: Yes. Especially when people start making jokes or using nicknames and slang. I might understand the work part but not the social part.

Interviewer: Is there someone on your team who is particularly good at helping with communication?

Participant: Yes. One coworker is very good at explaining things. She doesn't repeat the exact same sentence louder. She finds a different way to say it.

Interviewer: Have you ever felt like you were slowing the team down?

Participant: Sometimes, especially when we're very busy. Everyone is stressed, so if I ask someone to repeat something two or three times, I can feel a little awkward.

Interviewer: Imagine there was a shared device or robot that could support communication. What would you think about that?

Participant: It could be useful, but it needs to be really fast.

Interviewer: What would make it useful for you?

Participant: Maybe quick visual instructions or quick clarification. I wouldn't want to have a long conversation with a robot while I'm working.

Interviewer: Would you feel embarrassed using it in front of coworkers?

Participant: Not if everybody used it.

Interviewer: What if it was mainly designed for international workers?

Participant: Then I think it would feel strange. Like, "Oh, this is the robot for people who can't speak English." I wouldn't like that.

Interviewer: So you would prefer it to be a shared team tool?

Participant: Yes. Definitely. It should help everybody communicate, not just people who speak English as a second language.

Interviewer: Would you prefer it to translate directly for you or help your coworker communicate more clearly?

Participant: I think helping the coworker communicate more clearly could be interesting.

Interviewer: How might that work?

Participant: Maybe it could suggest, "Try explaining that in a simpler way," instead of just translating everything.

Interviewer: Would company ownership affect how you feel about the device?

Participant: Yes. I would want to know if conversations are being recorded.

Interviewer: Would you be comfortable if your manager could see what words you needed help with?

Participant: No. If it's helping me learn, that information should be private.

Interviewer: Do you think this tool could make coworkers more patient?

Participant: Maybe, but there's also a risk people become lazy and just say, "Use the robot."

Interviewer: Do you think it could strengthen workplace relationships?

Participant: It could, but only if it encourages people to talk more. Relationships come from communicating with each other.

Interviewer: Is there anything that a translation tool probably couldn't fix?

Participant: Humour and personality. Sometimes someone says something funny because of the way they say it. Translating it doesn't really give you the same feeling.

Interviewer: If you could design one feature for the device, what would it be?

Participant: Maybe a shared vocabulary feature. I could teach my coworkers some Spanish words and they could teach me Australian expressions.

Interviewer: Why would you like that?

Participant: Because then learning goes both ways. It's not just me trying to become more Australian. We can learn from each other.

Interview 3

Interviewer: Can you walk me through a recent time when language made your work more difficult?

Participant: During a design meeting, everyone was discussing different solutions very quickly. I understood what they were saying, but by the time I organised my answer in English, the conversation had already moved to another topic.

Interviewer: So was understanding English the main problem?

Participant: Not really. I understood most of the discussion. The difficult part was responding quickly.

Interviewer: How often does that happen?

Participant: Probably in most meetings.

Interviewer: Who do you usually ask when you don't understand something?

Participant: Usually I check the meeting notes first. If I'm still confused, I send somebody a message on Slack after the meeting.

Interviewer: Why do you prefer doing it afterwards?

Participant: It gives me more time to think about exactly what I want to ask.

Interviewer: Have you ever avoided asking a question in a meeting?

Participant: Yes. Sometimes I think maybe somebody already explained it and I just missed it.

Interviewer: What tools do you currently use?

Participant: Automatic captions are useful. Sometimes I also use AI to check whether an English message sounds natural before sending it.

Interviewer: How useful are captions?

Participant: Very useful when someone speaks quickly. But they don't solve everything.

Interviewer: What do they not solve?

Participant: Things like sarcasm, humour, or when somebody is being indirect.

Interviewer: Does asking for help feel different one-on-one compared with in a group?

Participant: Yes. One-on-one is much easier.

Interviewer: Why?

Participant: In a group, I'm not always sure when I should interrupt or when it's my turn to speak.

Interviewer: Have you ever felt like you weren't able to contribute because of that?

Participant: Yes. Sometimes I have an idea, but before I can explain it, somebody else starts speaking.

Interviewer: Has anyone ever finished your sentence for you?

Participant: Yes.

Interviewer: How does that feel?

Participant: I think they're trying to help, but sometimes they say something slightly different from what I actually wanted to say.

Interviewer: Imagine there was a robot or shared device supporting communication during meetings. What would you think?

Participant: I would be interested, but I wouldn't want it translating everything all the time.

Interviewer: Why not?

Participant: It could become distracting, especially when I already understand most of the conversation.

Interviewer: What kind of support would be useful?

Participant: Maybe something that helps with participation.

Interviewer: Can you explain what you mean?

Participant: Maybe I could press a button to indicate that I want to speak. Then the group knows I have something to say, but I can have a few seconds to prepare.

Interviewer: Would you feel comfortable using the robot in front of coworkers?

Participant: Yes, if everyone used it.

Interviewer: Would you feel differently if the robot announced that you didn't understand something?

Participant: Yes. I definitely wouldn't want that.

Interviewer: Would you rather the robot translate for you or help everyone communicate more clearly?

Participant: Help everyone communicate more clearly.

Interviewer: Why?

Participant: Because translation doesn't solve problems like people speaking too quickly or interrupting each other.

Interviewer: Since the device would belong to the company, would privacy concern you?

Participant: Yes. If it listens to meetings, I want to know where that information is stored.

Interviewer: What if the system kept a history of the language support you needed?

Participant: I would not want that connected to my employee profile.

Interviewer: Why?

Participant: Because language support should help people improve, not become part of evaluating their performance.

Interviewer: Could a tool like this improve relationships between coworkers?

Participant: Maybe, if it encourages everyone to communicate better.

Interviewer: Is there anything a support tool probably couldn't fix?

Participant: Cultural context. For example, sometimes everyone laughs at a joke and I understand all the words, but I still don't understand why it is funny.

Interviewer: If you could design one feature for the robot, what would it be?

Participant: A feature that gives everybody a fair opportunity to speak during meetings.

Interviewer: Anything else you think is important for us to understand?

Participant: Sometimes people assume that if somebody speaks slowly, they don't understand the topic. But maybe they just need more time to express the same idea in another language.